



Telephone frustrations

1 Complete the list of possible telephone frustrations using the verbs in the box.

call get (x 3) listen play put repeat return take transfer

- a** They _____ irritating music when you're put on hold.
- b** You _____ cut off in the middle of your call.
- c** People you call _____ a long time to answer.
- d** They _____ you on hold and forget about you.
- e** They _____ you to another person and you have to _____ your enquiry.
- f** They don't _____ properly to what you are saying.
- g** You continually _____ an engaged tone when you _____ someone.
- h** People don't _____ your calls.
- i** You _____ through to a voicemail system.

2 With a partner, decide which of the problems in 1 are the five most frustrating. Then look on page 136 to compare your answers with the results of a survey. Are there any other things that frustrate you when using the telephone?

3 Work with a partner and answer the questions.

- a** With the growth of the Internet, email and text messaging, how important is the telephone in business these days?
- b** What skills do staff who answer the phone need to have?
- c** Does bad telephone customer service have an impact on the success of a business?

4 Now read the article. According to the author, what are the answers to the questions in 3?

5 The author suggests, 'More business is lost through bad service than by poor product performance.' Do you agree? Discuss with a partner.



Effective Phone Communication

In this age of the Internet, email and electronic communication, the telephone is still one of the most important business tools. Customers expect to be dealt with professionally and competently, so effective phone communication skills are vital. Good customer service can give a company a competitive edge, while ineffective telephone behaviour can cost millions in lost sales opportunities.

Apart from a positive attitude, whatever business you are in, staff dealing with phone enquiries need training in a number of essential skills. These include transferring a call, placing a call on hold, dealing with angry callers, responding to enquiries about correspondence, using a caller's name and taking messages correctly. Callers should not hear informal expressions like 'Oh, she's just gone out' or 'Sorry, he's not with us anymore'. Customers want a prompt response from a real person (not a machine) who is friendly, helpful and can make a decision.

More business is lost through poor service than by poor product performance, and the quality of a company's response to a call is one of the chief factors in creating a perception of good or bad service.